prescribe in what manner, and for how long time, visitors shall be allowed to see or stay with the prisoners, according to the circumstances of every case in his discretion.

By the Court.

There were, besides, in this prison, as in the Fleet, certain printed rules made by the prisoners themselves, "to be obeyed and observed by every member of this college" (as they were pleased to term it). Many of them were arbitrary and improper: but now they are abolished.

MARSHALSEA PRISON [1]

To this prison of the Court of the Marshalsea, and of the King's Palace Court of Westminster, are brought debtors arrested for the lowest sums, anywhere within twelve miles of the palace, except in the City of London: and also persons committed for piracy.

The deputy marshal, under whose particular custody this prison is, has his appointment from the knight marshal of the king's household [2] for the time being. The great abuses practised by this officer were reported to Parliament by the gaol committee in 1729.

This prison is held under several leases by the widow of the late deputy marshal at the yearly rent of £101. It is an old irregular building (rather several buildings) in a spacious court. There are, in the whole, near sixty rooms; and yet only six of them left for common-side debtors. Of the other rooms—five were let to a man who was not a prisoner: in one of them he kept a chandler's shop; in two he lived with his family: the other two he let to prisoners. Four rooms, the Oaks, were for women. They were too few for the number; and the more modest women complained of the bad company, in which they were confined. There were above forty rooms for men on the master's-side, in which were about sixty beds; yet at my first visits, many prisoners had no beds nor any place to sleep in, but the chapel, and the tap-room. The chamber-rent wants regulation; for in several rooms where four lie in two beds, and in some dark rooms where two lie in one bed, each pays 3s. 6d. a week for his lodging.

[1] Abolished 1849.—[Ed.]

[2] The prison was originally established for the trial of servants of the royal household.

The prison is greatly out of repair. No infirmary. The court is well supplied with water. In it the prisoners play at rackets, etc., and in a little back court, the Park, at skittles.

The tap was let to a prisoner in the rules of the King's Bench Prison; this prison being just within those rules. I was credibly informed, that one Sunday in the summer 1775, about six hundred pots of beer were brought in from a public house in the neighbourhood (Ashmore's), the prisoners not then liking the tapster's beer.

In March 1775, when the number of prisoners was a hundred and seventy-five, there were with them in this incommodious prison wives and children forty-six.

Since the Act of the nineteenth of George III, chap. lxx, there are not so many debtors in this prison as formerly; yet they are increasing, for I find here, and in other prisons, many debtors whose original debts are much under £10, but for the purpose of imprisoning such debtors, they are prosecuted either in the Court of Exchequer, or in other inferior courts, until the expenses of such prosecutions which added to the original debt amount to £10. A fresh action is then taken out in the superior courts, for the small original debt, and the accumulated costs of prosecution. Thus the salutary purposes of the said Act are defeated.

Mr. Henry Allnott, who was many years since a prisoner here, had, during his confinement, a large estate bequeathed to him. He learned sympathy by his sufferings; and left £100 a year for discharging poor debtors from hence, whose debts do not exceed £4. As he bound his manor of Goring in Oxfordshire for charitable uses, this is called the Oxford charity. Many are cleared by it every year.